Grade 6–8 reference book

Figured bass, the chords of a key, progressions, the part-writing checklist, cadences, notes outside the chord, modulation, devices, the orchestra, composing and terms; then the Grade 7 and Grade 8 chords, writing questions and transposing instruments.

1. FIGURED BASS: WHAT THE FIGURES MEAN

Count up from the bass in letter names, inside the key signature. A dash after a figure means hold that note into the next chord.

Figure	Short for	Chord position	Example in C (bass → chord)
(none)	5/3	root position (a)	C → C–E–G
6	6/3	first inversion (b)	E → C–E–G
6/4	6/4	second inversion (c)	G → C–E–G
7	7/5/3	7th chord, root position	G → G–B–D–F
6/5	6/5/3	7th chord, first inversion	B → G–B–D–F
4/3	6/4/3	7th chord, second inversion	D → G–B–D–F
4/2 (or 2)	6/4/2	7th chord, third inversion	F → G–B–D–F
♯ or ♮ alone	raised 3rd	the 3rd above the bass is raised	in A minor, E with ♯ → E–G♯–B
♯6, ♮6 …	raised 6th	that note is raised	in A minor, B with ♯6 → G♯ above

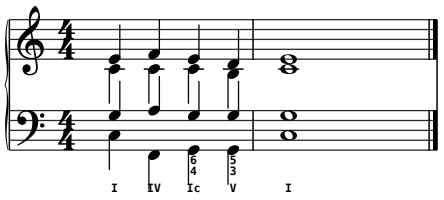
2. THE CHORDS OF A KEY

In minor, use the harmonic minor for chords: V and VII have the raised leading note. II is diminished in minor, so use IIb. VIIb is a diminished chord used in first inversion (like V7 without its root). III is rarely used at Grade 6.

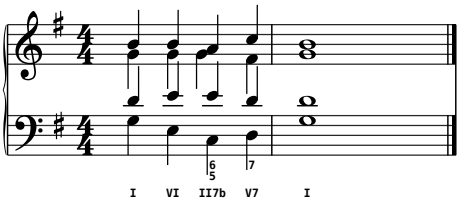
	C major	quality	A minor (harmonic)	quality
I	C–E–G	major	A–C–E	minor
II	D–F–A	minor	B–D–F	diminished
III	E–G–B	minor	C–E–G♯	augmented
IV	F–A–C	major	D–F–A	minor
V	G–B–D	major	E–G♯–B	major
VI	A–C–E	minor	F–A–C	major
VII	B–D–F	diminished	G♯–B–D	diminished

3. PROGRESSIONS TO KNOW BY HEART

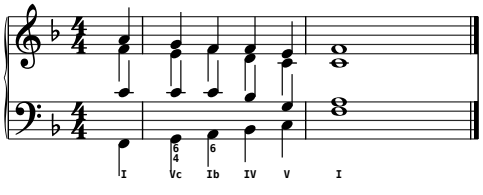
Models made by the app's harmony engine: complete chords, smooth parts, no consecutive 5ths or octaves.



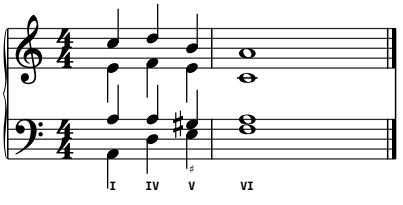
Cadential 6/4: Ic–V–I (C major)



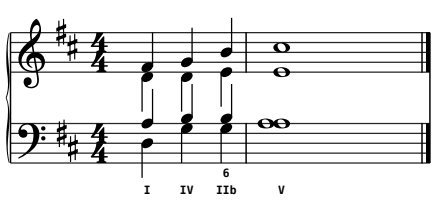
II7b – V7 – I (G major)



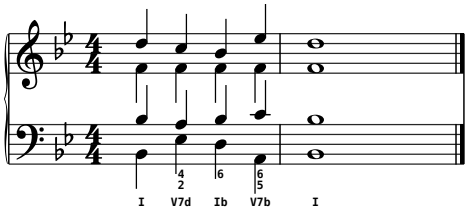
Passing 6/4: I – Vc – Ib (F major)



Interrupted cadence V – VI (A minor)



Imperfect cadence: IIb – V (D major)



V7 inversions resolving (B♭ major)

WHICH CHORD COMES NEXT?

Avoid V → IV. Strong root movements: up a 4th or down a 5th (V–I, II–V, VI–II).

From	Good next chords
I	any chord: IV, II, V, VI, Ib …
Ib	IV, II, V
II, IIb, II7b	V, V7 or Ic (then V)
IV	V, Ic, II, I
V, V7	I, or VI (interrupted)
VI	IV, II, V
VIIb	I or Ib
Ic	V or V7 over the same bass (cadential 6/4)

4. THE PART-WRITING CHECKLIST
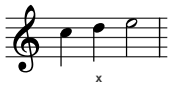
1. Every chord complete: root and 3rd always; 5th may go in root-position V7 or a final I.
2. Doubling: double the root in root position; in a 6/4 double the bass; in first inversion double the root or 5th (IIb: double the bass). Never double the leading note or a 7th.
3. Ranges: soprano C4–G5, alto G3–D5, tenor C3–G4, bass E2–D4. Keep soprano–alto and alto–tenor within an octave.
4. No parts crossing or overlapping.
5. No consecutive 5ths or octaves between any pair of parts (check all six pairs). No hidden octaves in the outer parts on a leap.
6. The leading note rises to the tonic (in an inner part at a cadence it may fall to the 5th).
7. The 7th of a 7th chord falls by step.
8. In minor: write the raised leading note's accidental every time; avoid the augmented 2nd (6th to raised 7th) in a part.
9. 6/4 chords only as cadential (Ic–V), passing (I–Vc–Ib) or auxiliary/pedal (I–IVc–I).
10. Keep common notes in the same part; move other parts to the nearest note.

5. CADENCES
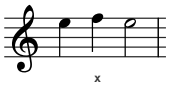
Cadence	Chords	Notes
Perfect	V–I or V7–I (both root position)	Ic–V–I is the strongest; melody 2–1 or 7–8
Imperfect	I, Ib, II, IIb, IV or Ic → V	ends on V: sounds unfinished
Plagal	IV–I	the 'Amen' cadence
Interrupted	V–VI	the surprise; in minor double the 3rd of VI

6. NOTES OUTSIDE THE CHORD
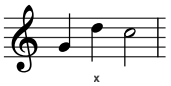
x marks the note outside the chord. Passing and auxiliary notes are usually off the beat; appoggiaturas and suspensions fall on the beat.
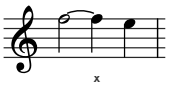


Passing note: steps between two chord notes
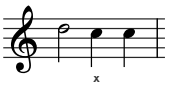


Auxiliary note: steps away and back
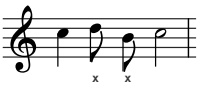


Appoggiatura: a clash ON the beat, often leapt to, resolving by step



Suspension: held over, clashes, falls by step (4–3, 7–6, 9–8)



Anticipation: the next chord's note, sounded early



Changing notes: step above and below (or below and above), then the chord note

7. RELATED KEYS AND MODULATION

A major key most often modulates to its dominant (new sharp or lost flat: the raised 4th). A minor key most often goes to its relative major (the raised 7th is cancelled). A pivot chord belongs to both keys: in C → G, A minor is VI in C and II in G.

Key	Relative minor	Dominant	Subdominant
C major	A minor	G major (and E minor)	F major (and D minor)
G major	E minor	D major (and B minor)	C major (and A minor)
D major	B minor	A major (and F♯ minor)	G major (and E minor)
A major	F♯ minor	E major (and C♯ minor)	D major (and B minor)
E major	C♯ minor	B major (and G♯ minor)	A major (and F♯ minor)
F major	D minor	C major (and A minor)	B♭ major (and G minor)
B♭ major	G minor	F major (and D minor)	E♭ major (and C minor)
E♭ major	C minor	B♭ major (and G minor)	A♭ major (and F minor)
A♭ major	F minor	E♭ major (and C minor)	D♭ major (and B♭ minor)

8. MUSICAL DEVICES

Device	What to look for
rising sequence	The same shape is repeated, starting a step higher each time.
falling sequence	The same shape is repeated, starting a step lower each time.
imitation	One part plays a phrase, then another part copies it while the first carries on.
inversion	The second phrase turns the first upside down: where it went up, it now goes down by the same steps.
augmentation	The second phrase repeats the first with the note values doubled.
syncopation	The accents fall off the beat: notes start between beats and are held across them.
tonic pedal	The bass holds (or repeats) the tonic while the harmony above changes.
dominant pedal	The bass holds (or repeats) the dominant while the harmony above changes.
Alberti bass	The left hand breaks each chord into the pattern low–high–middle–high.
hemiola	In 3/4, two bars are grouped as if they were three bars of 2/4: three minims across two bars, usually just before a cadence.
ostinato	A short pattern is repeated over and over in the bass.
repetition	The phrase is repeated exactly.

9. THE ORCHESTRA

String terms: arco, pizzicato, con sordino, sul ponticello, divisi, tremolo, double stopping. Brass/wind: tongued, a 2 (both players), 1. (first player only).

Family (score order)	Instruments, top to bottom	Clef	Sounds
Woodwind	piccolo	treble	an octave higher than written
	flute, oboe	treble	as written
	cor anglais	treble	a 5th lower
	clarinet in B♭ / A	treble	a major 2nd / minor 3rd lower
	bassoon	bass (tenor high)	as written

Family (score order)	Instruments, top to bottom	Clef	Sounds
Brass	horn in F	treble (often no key signature)	a 5th lower
	trumpet in B♭	treble	a major 2nd lower
	trombone	tenor or bass	as written
	tuba	bass	as written
Percussion	timpani	bass	as written
Strings	violin I, violin II	treble	as written
	viola	alto	as written
	cello	bass (tenor high)	as written
	double bass	bass	an octave lower

10. COMPOSING A MELODY: THE EXAMINER'S CHECKLIST

Plan before writing: bars 1–4 end on an imperfect cadence (degree 2, 5 or 7); bars 5–8 modulate and come back; the last bar ends on the tonic. Sing it in your head as you write.

1. 8 bars, and every bar adds up to the time signature
2. Two balanced phrases, with a clear cadence at bar 4
3. The opening's rhythm or shape comes back (repeat, sequence or a variation)
4. It modulates clearly (a new accidental, or in a minor key cancelling the raised 7th to reach the relative major) and comes back home
5. A clear high point, and a good shape: mostly steps with some leaps
6. It ends on the tonic, on a strong beat
7. It stays in the instrument's range and suits the instrument
8. A tempo marking (an Italian term is fine)
9. Dynamics, including at least one change
10. Phrasing slurs and some articulation (staccato, accents, tenuto)

11. TERMS

Grade 1

allegro: fast, lively
andante: at a walking pace
adagio: slow
moderato: at a moderate speed
allegretto: fairly quick
lento: slow
rallentando (rall.): gradually getting slower
accelerando (accel.): gradually getting faster
a tempo: back to the original speed
crescendo (cresc.): gradually getting louder
diminuendo (dim.): gradually getting quieter
mezzo forte (mf): moderately loud
pianissimo (pp): very quiet
fortissimo (ff): very loud
legato: smoothly
staccato: detached
da capo (D.C.): repeat from the beginning
fine: the end
cantabile: in a singing style
dolce: sweetly
poco: a little
molto: very, much
forte (f): loud
piano (p): quiet
ritardando (ritard., rit.): gradually getting slower
decrescendo (decresc.): gradually getting quieter

Grade 2

presto: very fast
largo: slow and stately
vivace: lively, quick
dal segno (D.S.): repeat from the sign
più: more
meno: less
sempre: always
subito: suddenly
tenuto: held
grazioso: gracefully
con moto: with movement
ritenuto (rit.): held back
sforzando (sf): forced, with a sudden accent
mezzo piano (mp): moderately quiet
fortepiano (fp): loud, then immediately quiet
prestissimo: as fast as possible
ottava (8va): play an octave higher
da capo al fine: repeat from the beginning and stop at Fine
ma: but
non: not
troppo: too much
con: with
alla marcia: in the style of a march

Grade 3

ma non troppo: but not too much
espressivo: expressively
leggiero: lightly
maestoso: majestically
sostenuto: sustained
tranquillo: calmly
giocoso: playful, merry
energico: with energy

tempo primo: at the first speed
pesante: heavily
marcato: emphatic, accented
risoluto: boldly
semplice: simply
vivo: lively, quick
delicato: delicately
l'istesso tempo: at the same speed

Grade 4

assai: very
rubato: with some freedom of time
agitato: restless, worried
animato: animated, lively
scherzando: playfully, jokingly
con sordino: with a mute
senza: without
stringendo: gradually getting faster
allargando: broadening, getting slower
mesto: sad
pizzicato: plucked
arco: with the bow
una corda: press the soft pedal
lent: slow (French)
vite: quick (French)
modéré: at a moderate speed (French)

larghetto: rather slow (less slow than largo)
con brio: with vigour, lively
tempo comodo: at a comfortable speed
deciso: decisively
affettuoso: tenderly
tre corde: release the soft pedal
simile: in the same way
come prima: as before
animé: animated, lively (French)
retenu: held back (French)
douce: sweet (French)
alla breve: two minim beats in a bar
amabile: lovable, pleasant
appassionato: passionately
misterioso: mysteriously
ritmico: rhythmically

Grade 5

morendo: dying away
sotto voce: in a hushed voice, very quietly
langsam: slow (German)
schnell: fast (German)
mässig: at a moderate speed (German)
ruhig: peaceful (German)
lebhaft: lively (German)
ad libitum (ad lib.): at choice, freely
quasi: as if, almost
smorzando (smorz.): dying away in tone and speed
perdendosi: dying away, fading

attacca: go straight on to the next section
a niente: dying away to nothing
traurig: sad (German)
cantando: singing
con dolore: with grief
doloroso: sorrowfully
largamente: broadly
con spirito: with spirit
rinforzando (rf, rfz): reinforcing, with a sudden accent
sonoro: resonant
sforzato (sfz): forced, accented
tristamente: sadly

Grade 6

divisi (div.): divided: the section splits onto separate notes
unisono (unis.): together again: all play the same notes
col legno: with the wood of the bow
sul ponticello: bow near the bridge
sul tasto: bow over the fingerboard
senza sordino: without a mute
tremolo: rapid repetition of a note, or quick alternation of two notes
a 2: both players play the same part
tutti: everyone plays
solo: one player alone
calando: getting softer and slower
brillante: brilliantly
con forza: with force
furioso: furiously
lacrimoso: tearfully, sadly
lusingando: coaxing, charmingly
nobilmente: nobly
piacevole: pleasantly

pomposo: pompously, grandly
strepitoso: noisily, boisterously
tempo giusto: in strict time
veloce: swiftly
vigoroso: vigorously
volante: flying, fast and light
incalzando: pressing on, getting quicker
slentando: getting slower
stretto: getting faster (pressing on)
tenerezza (con): with tenderness
lent et doux: slow and soft (French)
en dehors: bring out the melody (French)
cédez: slow down (French)
en mesure: in time (French)
sourdine: mute (French)
bewegt: with movement (German)
breit: broadly (German)
etwas: somewhat (German)
sehr: very (German)
zart: tenderly, delicately (German)
mit Dämpfer: with a mute (German)

Hauptstimme: the main part: bring it out (German)

sons étouffés: damped, muffled notes (French)

laissez vibrer: let it

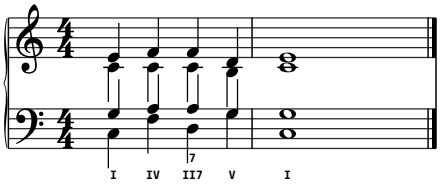
Grade 7

12. GRADE 7 CHORDS

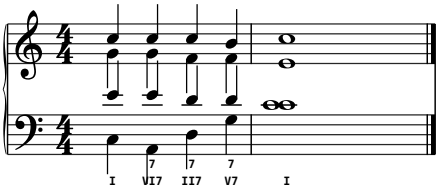
Secondary 7ths are 7th chords on any degree except V; their 7th is usually prepared and always falls by step. The diminished 7th is a stack of minor 3rds. The Neapolitan is the major chord on the flattened 2nd, in first inversion; double its bass.

Chord	In C major	In A minor	Figures (root, b, c, d)	Usually goes to
I7	C–E–G–B	—	7, 6/5, 4/3, 4/2	IV (the 7th falls)
II7	D–F–A–C	B–D–F–A	7, 6/5, 4/3, 4/2	V or Ic–V
IV7	F–A–C–E	—	7, 6/5, 4/3, 4/2	V
VI7	A–C–E–G	—	7, 6/5, 4/3, 4/2	II or II7
VII7 (diminished 7th, minor)	—	G♯–B–D–F	7, ♯6/5, ♯4/3, 4/♯2	I (leading note rises, 7th falls)
N6 (Neapolitan 6th)	D♭–F–A♭	B♭–D–F	♭6/♭ (C major), ♭6 (A minor)	V, or Ic–V

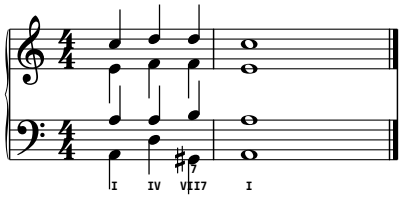
13. GRADE 7 PROGRESSIONS



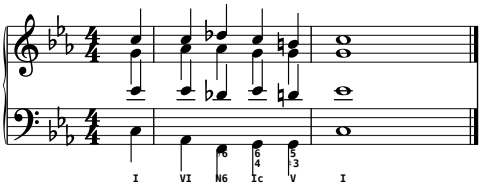
II7 before V (C major)



A chain of 7ths (C major)



Diminished 7th to I (A minor)



N6–Ic–V–I (C minor)

14. SUSPENSIONS

Preparation (a concord) → suspension (tied, clashing on the beat) → resolution (down a step). Don't double the note of resolution, except in 9–8.

Type	Clash above the bass	Resolves to	Figures	Typical place
4–3	4th	3rd	4 3 (4 ♯ in minor over V)	over V at a cadence
7–6	7th	6th	7 6	chains over first inversions
9–8	9th	octave	9 8	over a root-position chord
2–3 (bass)	the bass is held: a 2nd	3rd (the bass falls)	2 3 / 6 5	the bass falling by step

15. MELODIC DECORATION

Name	What it does
Passing note	steps between two chord notes
Auxiliary note	steps away and back
Appoggiatura	a clash on the beat, resolving by step
Anticipation	a note of the next chord, sounded early
Échappée	steps away, then leaps back the other way
Changing notes	step above and below (or below and above), then the chord note

16. TRANSPOSING INSTRUMENTS AND CLEFS

Instrument	Sounds	Written key signature (vs concert)
Clarinet in B♭, trumpet in B♭	a major 2nd lower	2 sharps more / 2 flats fewer
Clarinet in A	a minor 3rd lower	3 flats more / 3 sharps fewer
Horn in F, cor anglais	a perfect 5th lower	1 sharp more (horn often has no key signature)
Piccolo	an octave higher	same
Double bass	an octave lower	same

Alto clef (viola): middle C on the middle line. Tenor clef (cello, bassoon, trombone high notes): middle C on the 4th line.

17. GRADE 7 TERMS

attacca: go straight on to the next movement
col legno: with the wood of the bow
sul ponticello: bow near the bridge
sul tasto: bow over the fingerboard
flautando: bow lightly to give a flute-like sound
non vibrato: without vibrato
divisi (div.): divided: players share the notes
unisoni (unis.): together again after divisi
a 2: both players play the same part
morendo: dying away
perdendosi: dying away
smorzando (smorz.): dying away
calando: getting softer and slower
lusingando: coaxing, caressing
lacrimoso: tearful, sad
lugubre: mournful
misterioso: mysteriously
pesante: heavily
sostenuto: sustained
tranquillo: calmly
ad libitum (ad lib.): at the performer's choice (tempo or whether to play)
quasi: as if, almost
tempo primo (Tempo I): back to the first speed
cédez: slow down (French)
en dehors: brought out, prominent (French)
très: very (French)
un peu: a little (French)
sourdine: mute (French)
au mouvement: back to the original speed (French)
bewegt: with movement (German)
zart: tenderly, delicately (German)
gestopft: stopped: hand in the bell of the horn (German)
Flatterzunge: flutter-tonguing (German)
sehr: very (German)
etwas: somewhat, rather (German)
breit: broadly (German)
Schwungvoll: lively, with swing (German)

Grade 8

18. SECONDARY DOMINANTS

A secondary dominant is the dominant (or dominant 7th, or diminished 7th) of a chord other than I. It borrows that chord's leading note, so it brings an accidental.

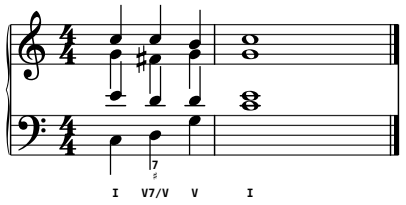
Chord	In C major	Figures (root)	Goes to	The note to watch
V/V	D–F♯–A	♯	V	F♯ rises to G
V7/V	D–F♯–A–C	7/♯	V (or Ic–V)	F♯ rises, C falls
V7/IV	C–E–G–B♭	♭7	IV	B♭ falls to A
V7/II	A–C♯–E–G	7/♯	II	C♯ rises to D
V7/VI	E–G♯–B–D	7/♯	VI	G♯ rises to A
VII7/V	F♯–A–C–E	7	V	F♯ rises, E♭ falls

19. AUGMENTED 6TH CHORDS

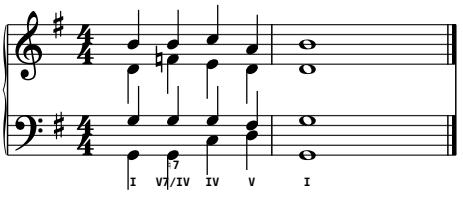
All three are built on the flattened 6th in the bass, with the sharpened 4th above: an augmented 6th that opens out to the octave on the dominant. Double the tonic in the Italian; never double the ♭6 or ♯4.

Chord	In C minor	In C major	Figures	Goes to
Italian 6th	A♭–C–F♯	A♭–C–F♯	♯6	V
French 6th	A♭–C–D–F♯	A♭–C–D–F♯	♯6/4/3	V
German 6th	A♭–C–E♭–F♯	A♭–C–E♭–F♯	♯6/5 (major: ♯6/♭5/♭3)	Ic then V (avoids consecutive 5ths)

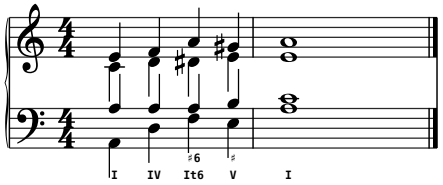
20. GRADE 8 PROGRESSIONS



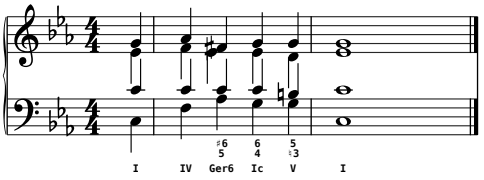
V7/V–V–I (C major)



V7/IV–IV–V–I (G major)



It6–V–I (A minor)



Ger6–Ic–V–I (C minor)

21. QUESTION 1: THE TRIO SONATA CHECKLIST

Pencil each chord's notes over the bass first. With three parts, keep the 3rd (and the 7th of a 7th chord); the 5th may go.

1. Every chord follows the figures, with the 3rd present
2. No consecutive 5ths or octaves between any two parts (including the bass)
3. The two violins are independent: contrary or oblique motion, some imitation or sequence
4. Leading notes rise, 7ths fall, suspensions are prepared and resolve down
5. The violins stay mostly within an octave of each other (they may cross)
6. Some quaver movement for life; a clear cadence at the end

22. QUESTION 2: KEYBOARD PATTERNS

Pattern	Time	Shape (in C)
Alberti bass	4/4 or 2/4	C–G–E–G
Broken chord	4/4	C–E–G–E
Waltz bass	3/4	C, then E+G, E+G
Rocking quavers	6/8	C–G–E, C–G–E

1. The pattern from bar 1 is kept exactly in shape and rhythm
2. Every bar fits the harmony implied by the melody and bass
3. Chromatic notes (secondary dominants, augmented 6ths) are spelled correctly
4. No consecutive octaves or 5ths between the melody and the bass
5. The cadence is clear, ending on a full tonic chord
6. The texture suits the piano: comfortable for the hands

23. QUESTION 3: A 12-BAR MELODY

Plan: bars 1–4 to an imperfect cadence; bars 5–8 modulate (dominant or relative); bars 9–12 come home, with the high point and a strong tonic ending.

1. At least 12 bars, every bar the right length
2. Clear phrases (often 4 + 4 + 4) with cadences at the ends
3. The opening idea comes back, varied or developed (sequence, inversion, new rhythm)
4. A modulation to a related key with the right accidental, then a clear return
5. One high point, a good balance of steps and leaps, a strong ending on the tonic
6. Written for the instrument: range, breathing or bowing, idiomatic figures
7. Tempo, dynamics with changes, phrasing and articulation

24. BRASS IN OLD KEYS AND OTHER TRANSPOSING INSTRUMENTS

The rule: an instrument 'in X' sounds X when it plays a written C. Classical horn and trumpet parts usually have no key signature.

Instrument	A written C sounds	Interval
Horn in F	F below	a perfect 5th lower
Horn in E♭	E♭ below	a major 6th lower
Horn in D	D below	a minor 7th lower
Trumpet in B♭	B♭ below	a major 2nd lower
Trumpet in D	D above	a major 2nd higher
Trumpet in F	F above	a perfect 4th higher
Clarinet in A	A below	a minor 3rd lower
Cor anglais (in F)	F below	a perfect 5th lower
Piccolo	C an octave above	an octave higher
Double bass, contrabassoon	C an octave below	an octave lower

25. GRADE 8 TERMS

sotto voce: in an undertone, quietly
mezza voce: at half voice, restrained
a piacere: freely, at the performer's pleasure
l'istesso tempo: at the same speed (the beat stays the same)
tempo rubato: with some freedom of time
mesto: sad
elegiaco: mournful, like an elegy
lamentoso: lamenting
con slancio: with dash, impetuously
affrettando: hurrying
allargando: broadening, getting slower and fuller
stringendo: pressing on, getting faster
incalzando: getting quicker and louder
piangevole: plaintive, tearful
lontano: distant
laissez vibrer: let it vibrate (don't damp the sound)
pressez: hurry (French)
en animant: getting livelier (French)
à volonté: freely, at will (French)
cuivré: brassy, a forced brass tone (French)
sur la touche: bow over the fingerboard (French)
Hauptstimme: the main part: bring it out (German)
Nebenstimme: a secondary part (German)
ausdrucksvoll: expressively (German)
kräftig: strong, vigorous (German)

zögernd: hesitating, slowing (German)
gedämpft: muted (German)
langsamer: slower (German)

lebhaft: lively (German)
nicht zu schnell: not too fast (German)
innig: heartfelt, intimate (German)

markiert: marked, a